

Wells Score — Deep Vein Thrombosis

adults, non-pregnant; not validated in pregnancy · casualty / ward

Wells DVT

Criterion	Original	Modified
Active cancer (treatment ongoing, within 6 months, or palliative)	+1	+1
Paralysis, paresis or recent plaster immobilisation of the legs	+1	+1
Bedridden ≥3 days or major surgery within 12 weeks	+1	+1
Localised tenderness along the deep venous system	+1	+1
Entire leg swollen	+1	+1
Calf swelling ≥3 cm vs asymptomatic side (10 cm below tibial tuberosity)	+1	+1
Pitting oedema confined to the symptomatic leg	+1	+1
Collateral superficial veins (non-varicose)	+1	+1
Previously documented DVT	—	+1
Alternative diagnosis at least as likely as DVT	-2	-2
Total (range)	-2 to 8	-2 to 9

INTERPRETATION

Original · three-tier	Low (≤ 0)	Moderate (1-2)	High (≥ 3)
Modified · two-level	DVT unlikely (≤ 1)		DVT likely (≥ 2)

PEARLS

- Score the symptomatic leg; if both legs symptomatic, score the worse leg
- Do not use D-dimer alone to rule out DVT in 'likely' patients
- Original 1997 score has no 'previous DVT' item — modified adds +1

NEXT STEPS

DVT likely (≥2)

- Proximal leg vein ultrasound, result within 4 h if possible
- Scan delayed → D-dimer + interim anticoagulation; scan within 24 h
- Scan negative + D-dimer positive → stop anticoag; repeat scan at 6-8 days

DVT unlikely (≤1)

- D-dimer (result within 4 h); anticoagulate if delayed
- D-dimer positive → proximal leg vein ultrasound (as for 'likely')
- D-dimer negative → DVT unlikely; stop anticoagulation

Age-adjusted D-dimer cut-off (age >50): cut-off (µg/L FEU) = age × 10 · validated in PE (ADJUST-PE); NICE: consider if >50

SA GUIDELINES

- Diagnosis is clinical, confirmed with Duplex Doppler +
- DDx: cellulitis, superficial thrombophlebitis, Baker's cyst, calf muscle tear, lymphoedema, venous insufficiency, knee derangement +
- Proximal DVT Rx: rivaroxaban 15 mg 12-hourly × 3 wk, then 20 mg daily × 3 months (check Table 2.5) +
- Pregnancy: confirm with compression duplex US; strong suspicion → enoxaparin 1 mg/kg SC 12-hourly + refer +